A just transition to a plant-based economy

A just transition to a plant-based economy 1
Just transition to a plant-based economy 1
Four overarching objectives 2
The ‘value’ of animal exploitation to New Zealand’s economy 2
Impacts on animals 3
Impacts on the environment 4
Impacts on human health 4
Other voices for change 6
A Treaty-Based Approach to Economic Transition 7
Objective 1: Increase consumption of plant-based foods 8
Make plant-based foods the default option for public institutions 8
Ensure fair and transparent labelling 10
Introduce plant-based eating initiatives and improve guidelines 12
Improve access to nutritious food 15
Objective 2: Use land and water sustainably and compassionately 18
Ban the most intensive and harmful forms of animal farming and fishing 18
Introduce tighter standards and enforcement for agricultural pollution 20
Provide financial incentives for good environmental practices 22
Objective 3: Support farmers, workers and communities to transition 24
Introduce a farm transition scheme 24
Support for rural economies to thrive without animal agriculture 27
Reskill workers within, and supporting, the industrial animal system 29
Objective 4: Develop long-term economic alternatives 31
Identify our biggest land-use and bioeconomy opportunities 31
Become a leader in alternative proteins 34

Version 3 – 13.04.25

Just transition to a plant-based economy

The AJP is committed to transitioning Aotearoa New Zealand to a wholly plant-based economy, where animal farming has been eliminated and no animals are used for economic gain. We acknowledge the role of Māori as tangata whenua (people of the land) and recognise the importance of kaitiakitanga, manaakitanga, and tino rangatiratanga in shaping a just transition. This transformation must be guided by partnership with iwi and hapū, respecting mātauranga Māori and supporting Māori economic aspirations through sustainable land-use practices. We want to create a more prosperous, sustainable and secure economy that is underpinned by compassion for all.

A transformation approach is required. We recognise that our current economic model is deeply reliant on the exploitation of animals for food, other products and exports. And that for many New Zealanders, including both Māori and Pākehā, have strong cultural and historical ties to animal farming. For Māori, these ties are often rooted in whakapapa and a deep ancestral relationship with the land, while for Pākehā, the connection has developed more recently through settler-colonial history and generations of farming. Understanding these different histories is essential as we navigate a just transition away from animal-based systems.

However, our current agricultural model has significant environmental impacts, including biodiversity loss, freshwater degradation and greenhouse gas emissions, while also inflicting unnecessary suffering on millions of sentient beings. It is also inherently risky as an on-going economic strategy, as environmental tipping points, new technologies, consumer preferences, societal concerns and changes in global trade threaten to reduce long term demand for animal products alongside increasing regulatory burdens. New Zealand is currently in a ‘chaos and emergence’ phase where existing systems are being questioned and new alternatives are emerging.[1]

We appreciate transitioning to a plant-based economy will take time, and that to be sustainable it must happen alongside support for farmers and the development of attractive and affordable alternatives for both farmers and consumers alike. There are, however, steps we can take now that will make a huge positive impact. These include banning factory farming, tougher laws, regulations and enforcement mechanisms, supporting farm livelihood transitions, engaging with Māori leadership, supporting innovation in food tech, and promoting and incentivising more compassionate and

[1] Klerkx, L., Turner, J., & Percy, H. (2023) Navigating the rapids of agrifood systems transformation: reflections on Aotearoa New Zealand’s emerging mission oriented agrifood innovation system

healthy dietary choices. He ara kai pai ake mō te tinana, te wairua me te taiao (healthier and more sustainable food pathways for the body, spirit, and environment).

Shifting to a plant-based economy is the single most impactful change we can make to reduce animal suffering whilst also addressing many of our most urgent economic, social and environmental challenges. Our vision is for a radically different economy. Our policy focuses on practical steps that can be implemented now to make this future possible.

Four overarching objectives

Our policy for transitioning to a plant-based economy is focussed on shifting away from animal agriculture and animal-based foods, and replacing these with sustainable and compassionate alternatives. It is centered around four objectives, each supported by specific proposals:

1. **Increase consumption of plant-based foods**. Use a variety of policy levers to increase consumption and market demand for healthier, kinder, more sustainable food options that align with kai ora (healthy food) principles

2. **Use land and water sustainably and compassionately**. Use regulation and incentives to shift from animal to plant-based farming and other sustainable land and water uses.

3. **Support farmers, workers and communities to transition**. Engage and collaborate to support a fair and inclusive transition with economic opportunities for all.

4. **Develop long-term economic alternatives**. Invest in new technologies, products and markets - to replace animal farming and provide prosperity and jobs.

To achieve these objectives, the Government should urgently develop a National Action Plan to implement the proposals set out in this document. While animal agriculture currently remains economically significant, there are both environmental and market pressures that suggest the potential for transition. Given this context, transitioning to a plant-based economy should be a national priority and the Government must play a critical role in making this happen.

The ‘value’ of animal exploitation to New Zealand’s economy

Despite its well documented negative impacts, animal agriculture occupies a prominent position in New Zealand's economy and national identity. While agriculture is often described as the foundation of New Zealand's economic prosperity, contributing to GDP,

exports and employment, the combined agricultural and fishing sectors represent approximately just 5% of GDP.

The dairy sector accounts for 3% of this (>$11BN) and provides an estimated 55,000 jobs. Dried milk powder is one of our most significant export commodities, with the dairy export trade earning around $1 in every $4 of New Zealand's foreign exchange income.[2] However, the expansion of dairy farming has led to economic vulnerabilities, including significant trade imbalances and a high reliance on imports. It has also resulted in environmental challenges, particularly regarding water quality.

Shifting away from these industries will be a significant challenge. New Zealand's agricultural identity, established during colonisation as the dairy farm of the British Empire, continues to shape its global economic position and national politics. A just transition requires redressing these injustices by prioritising Māori leadership in land-use decision-making, ensuring economic benefits are equitably distributed, and honoring Māori aspirations for self-determined food and land systems. The close alignment between agricultural and state interests has historically been reflected in strong rural sector representation in Parliament.[3] This deep institutional and political entrenchment, combined with significant industry influence over policy making, means that developing viable economic alternatives will require substantial time, innovation and investment.

It is imperative that we begin the transition to a plant-based economy with urgency. This is critical not only to protect the environment, our health, and millions of sentient beings, but also for our long-term economic prosperity. As consumers change dietary habits; as countries such as China prioritise food independence; and as innovation in food technology increasingly provides cruelty-free alternatives, there is a very real possibility that future market demand for New Zealand's animal products will decline. Shifting away from animal agriculture offers opportunities to diversify, build resilience, food security, and secure long-term economic prosperity.

Impacts on animals

Millions of farmed animals are slaughtered in New Zealand every year. Data from StatsNZ reveals that around 27 million 'livestock' were killed in 2023, including 21 million lambs and sheep, 4.6 million cows and 600,000 pigs, heifers, bulls, steers and calves. In addition, it is estimated that 120 million chickens are slaughtered annually.[4] Between 953 million to 5.94 billion wild-fish were killed for food (2016, Our World in Data), this estimate does not include unrecorded fish capture, such as bycatch and

[2] For an industry perspective see: Sense Partners. (2023). *Dairy's economic contribution to New Zealand.* https://www.dairynz.co.nz/media/0oibxesz/solid-foundations-4-september-2023.pdf
[3] Federated Farmers. (2023). From the back paddock to the Beehive. *Farmers Weekly.* https://www.farmersweekly.co.nz/politics/from-the-back-paddock-to-the-beehive/
[4] See: https://figure.nz/chart/3MTXwpL6IC7HriMp (sheep), https://figure.nz/chart/sTN0HlwsCBAbVCFz (livestock), https://figure.nz/chart/MvEo5sIoSRn18Ofd (cattle), https://figure.nz/chart/tkWQS2fpbiLVpF7N (pigs) and https://animalsaotearoa.org/learn/how-chickens-suffer-at-slaughter/ (chickens).

discards. Farmed fish, including salmon, mussels and oysters are killed in their hundreds of millions annually.

However, the impact on farmed animals cannot be captured by numbers alone. Poor conditions and cruel practices are widespread. New Zealand's animal welfare laws are inadequate even when they are adhered to, but in practice we know that legal minimum standards are often not met - with negative consequences for the sentient beings that are powerless to resist. Whilst high welfare standards are better than low / no standards, ultimately the only ethically justifiable course of action is to phase out animal farming altogether.

Impacts on the environment

Animal farming is a major driver of climate change. Globally it is responsible for between 10% and 20% of global GHG emissions, and it is one of the leading causes of deforestation.[5] 48.6% of New Zealand's total emissions in 2022 came from sheep and cattle, of which 25.7% was from dairy cattle, 12.4% from sheep and 10.5% from beef cattle.[6] The inefficiency of producing food through animals also means that shifting to plant-based foods has the potential to release large tracts of land for ecosystem restoration and reforestation - critical parts of the solution to climate change.[7] In New Zealand around half of all land is used for agriculture, the vast majority of which is for grazing.[8]

Animal farming also has severe effects on rivers and waterways - degrading ecosystems, killing animals and reducing water quality. Many Māori communities bear the brunt of these effects, with degraded rivers, pollution, and land-use pressures disproportionately affecting Māori land and resources. In New Zealand the Ministry for the Environment has estimated that 95% of waterways whose catchments included areas of farmland exceed guideline values for water turbidity or dissolved nutrients; and that 24% of total river length in those catchments had E. coli levels that were greater than would be expected under natural conditions.[9] Algal growth in streams and rivers - caused by fertiliser runoff - is widespread, leading to impairment of water for swimming, drinking and fish and other wildlife.

Impacts on human health

The rise in consumption of animal products over the past decades correlates with increasing rates of chronic disease in New Zealand and globally. Research demonstrates clear associations between high consumption of animal products and

[5] Estimates vary depending on a variety of assumptions and methodological approaches. For a recent summary see this article by The Breakthrough Institute (2023).
[6] https://www.nzagrc.org.nz/news-and-events/race-on-to-reduce-emissions-from-new-zealand-livestock/
[7] For a summary of animal agriculture and global land use see:Poore & Nemeck (2018) *Reducing food's environmental impacts* and https://ourworldindata.org/global-land-for-agriculture.
[8] See: https://www.ehinz.ac.nz/assets/Factsheets/Released_2021/Agricultural-Land-Use_FA.pdf
[9] See: MfE (2020): https://environment.govt.nz/publications/our-freshwater-2020/

adverse health outcomes. Specifically, red and processed meat consumption is linked to increased risk of colorectal cancer, with the World Health Organisation classifying processed meat as a Group 1 carcinogen, alongside alcohol and tobacco.[10] High consumption of animal products is associated with increased risk of cardiometabolic diseases, certain cancers, and all-cause mortality.[11]

Conversely, scientific evidence consistently shows that plant-based diets play both preventative and therapeutic roles in managing major chronic conditions including cardiovascular disease, type 2 diabetes, obesity, and certain cancers. Studies indicate that replacing animal-based foods (such as red meat, processed meat, eggs, and dairy) with plant-based alternatives (including legumes, nuts, whole grains, and olive oil) improves cardiometabolic health outcomes.[12]
Plant-based diets are demonstrated to be safe and nutritionally adequate across all life stages, from pregnancy and lactation through to elderly care, when appropriately planned.. Beyond individual health benefits, transitioning toward plant-based agriculture could significantly reduce the growing burden on our healthcare system. Shifting toward predominantly plant-based diets is not only feasible but could substantially improve public health outcomes, reduce healthcare costs by $11 to 22 billion,[13] and help address ethnic health inequities,[14] as Māori and Pacific communities bear a disproportionate burden of diet-related diseases. This transition presents an opportunity to move from a healthcare system focused on treating chronic diseases to one centered on prevention through dietary change.

In a plant-based economy, the risk of food-borne illnesses, pandemics and antibiotic resistance would be significantly reduced, creating a safer and more resilient food system. Industrial animal agriculture is a breeding ground for dangerous pathogens, with cramped, unsanitary conditions allowing bacteria and viruses—such as Salmonella, E. coli, and even pandemic-causing influenza strains[15]—to spread rapidly. Additionally, the heavy use of antibiotics in livestock farming fuels the rise of antibiotic-resistant

---

[10] https://www.who.int/news-room/questions-and-answers/item/cancer-carcinogenicity-of-the-consumption-of-red-meat-and-processed-meat

[11] van Dooren, C. et al.(2018). White paper: Towards a more plant-based diet

[12] Neuenschwander, M., Stadelmaier, J., Eble, J. et al. Substitution of animal-based with plant-based foods on cardiometabolic health and all-cause mortality: a systematic review and meta-analysis of prospective studies. BMC Med 21, 404 (2023). https://doi.org/10.1186/s12916-023-03093-1

[13] https://healthierlives.co.nz/wp-content/uploads/Modelling-methods-and-theoretical-scenarios.pdf

[14] Cleghorn C, Nghiem N, Ni Mhurchu C. Assessing the Health and Environmental Benefits of a New Zealand Diet Optimised for Health and Climate Protection. Sustainability. 2022; 14(21):13900. https://doi.org/10.3390/su142113900

[15] Zhang, T. et al. (2024). The impacts of animal agriculture on One Health—Bacterial zoonosis, antimicrobial resistance, and beyond. One Health, vol 18 https://doi.org/10.1016/j.onehlt.2024.100748

superbugs, threatening human medicine.[16] By shifting to a plant-based food system, we remove these high-risk environments, reducing the likelihood of zoonotic disease outbreaks and preserving the effectiveness of life-saving antibiotics. A future built on plant-based foods is not only kinder to animals and the planet but also crucial for global public health.

Other voices for change

The AJP is not alone in advocating for a transition to a plant-based economy.

The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change has said that shifting to more sustainable diets is a major opportunity to reduce global GHG emissions, with a theoretical global shift to wholly plant-based diets saving up to 8Gt CO_2e p/a (~13% of total current global emissions).[17]

At the national level some countries are now implementing measures to support a reduction in animal based foods. For example the Netherlands has a goal to reduce meat consumption by 50% by 2030,[18] in October 2023 the Danish government published a national plant-based action plan with its strategy to transition Denmark towards a richer plant-based diet and boost plant-protein production [19][20] and France's Climate and Resilience law (2021) encourages school canteens to serve more vegetarian meals.[21]

At a regional level, California's Plant-Based School Lunch Act (2022) provides additional reimbursements to schools serving plant-based meals, incentivising more plant-based options in school cafeterias[22] and New York City hospitals offer plant-based dishes as the default option since 2022. [23] Most large schools and universities in the U.S., France and Germany offer regular meatless meal options.[24]

---

[16] Pandey S, Doo H, Keum GB, Kim ES, Kwak J, Ryu S, Choi Y, Kang J, Kim S, Lee NR, Oh KK, Lee JH, Kim HB. Antibiotic resistance in livestock, environment and humans: One Health perspective. J Anim Sci Technol. 2024 Mar;66(2):266-278. doi: 10.5187/jast.2023.e129. Epub 2024 Mar 31. PMID: 38628683; PMCID: PMC11016740.

[17] IPCC (2019) Climate Change and Land: an IPCC special report

[18] More on the Dutch National Protein Strategy can be found here.

[19] https://en.fvm.dk/Media/638484294982868221/Danish-Action-Plan-for-Plant-based-Foods.pdf

[20] https://www.greenqueen.com.hk/denmark-green-research-innovation-fund-plant-based-agriculture-climate-change/?utm_source=green-queen-future-food-weekly.beehiiv.com&utm_medium=newsletter&utm_campaign=would-you-drink-watermelon-seed-milk-future-food-weekly

[21] https://www.theveganreview.com/france-climate-change-resilience-law-reduces-meat-school-menus/

[22] https://leginfo.legislature.ca.gov/faces/billVersionsCompareClient.xhtml?bill_id=201920200AB479&cversion=20190AB47999INT#:~:text=A%20single%20meal%20with%20both,reimbursement%20amounts%20in%20quarterly%20installments.

[23] https://www.nychealthandhospitals.org/pressrelease/nyc-health-hospitals-now-serving-plant-based-meals-as-primary-dinner-option-for-inpatients-at-all-of-its-11-public-hospitals/

[24] https://rethinkpriorities.org/research-area/plant-based-meal-campaigns-in-the-us-western-europe/

Civil society initiatives, such as the Plant Based Treaty,[25] provide ways for individuals, organisations and communities to shift towards plant-based diets. The AJP supports the Plant Based Treaty, and become a signatory in 2024.

A Treaty-Based Approach to Economic Transition

The AJP recognises that the transition to a plant-based economy must be grounded in Te Tiriti o Waitangi me ngā mātāpono o te ao Māori (the Treaty of Waitangi and Māori worldviews), ensuring that Māori are central partners in shaping Aotearoa's future. By integrating mātauranga Māori, supporting indigenous food sovereignty, and investing in Māori-led agricultural transformation, we can create a truly sustainable, compassionate and equitable economy for all. This includes recognising practices such as maramataka (Māori lunar planting cycles) and māra kai (community food gardens) as part of broader environmental restoration and food sovereignty initiatives.

The Government has a critical role in ensuring this transition is just, inclusive, and reflective of Aotearoa's unique bicultural identity. By working in genuine partnership with Māori, we can create an economic model that protects the environment, enhances well-being, and upholds the principles of Te Tiriti o Waitangi.

"Me whai kia whakamana te reo Māori, mātauranga Māori, me ngā tikanga tuku iho i roto i tēnei huringa ōhanga. **(We must ensure that te reo Māori, Māori knowledge, and customary practices are upheld throughout this economic transition.)"**

[25] https://plantbasedtreaty.org/

Objective 1: Increase consumption of plant-based foods

Make plant-based foods the default option for public institutions

The AJP proposes to increase the availability of plant-based foods in schools, hospitals and other public institutions and events - by making nutritious plant-based foods the default option.

At the current time our public institutions offer little in the way of alternatives to animal-based foods, even in settings like hospitals where health and nutrition alone should be a strong motive for change. Increasing the availability and visibility of delicious plant-based foods is a low-cost high-impact way of increasing demand for these products and supporting more sustainable, healthy and compassionate consumer choices. This in turn has the potential to create a ripple effect beyond public institutions by influencing broader community eating habits and private organisations.

Similar initiatives have been implemented with success elsewhere in the world. For example in New York in 2022 plant-based meals were made the default option across 11 public hospitals. The initiative was introduced to address both health and environmental objectives. By early 2024 over 1.2 million plant-based meals had been served with an 80%+ satisfaction rate, and with discharged patients receiving a free booklet of plant-based recipes to try at home. This also led to an estimated 36% reduction in planet-heating greenhouse gas pollution, pointing to the contribution these initiatives can make towards organisational carbon reduction efforts.[26]

To implement these initiatives in Aotearoa, we will also encourage the use of rooftops, courtyards, and other green spaces in public institutions to create edible gardens. These gardens can supply fresh, seasonal ingredients directly to institutional kitchens - the ultimate in "farm to plate" - while also providing educational and therapeutic value. Patients, students, staff, and visitors observing or participating in these gardens may be inspired to grow food at home, creating a ripple effect beyond the institution. Globally, edible landscapes are being successfully used in hospitals,[27] schools,[28] and community centres[29] to reconnect people with food, promote sustainability and enhance wellbeing.

---

[26] NYC Health and Hospitals (2024) - Hospitals celebrate 1.2 million plant-based meals served
[27] https://www.bmc.org/nourishing-our-community/rooftop-farm
[28] https://www.ediblegardencity.com/key-projects
[29] https://www.theguardian.com/world/2018/may/09/incredible-edible-yorkshire-towns-food-growing-scheme-takes-root-worldwide

To implement these initiatives effectively, we will work with hauora Māori (Māori health providers), tohunga kai (food experts), and food suppliers to develop culturally appropriate guidelines and menus that prioritise plant-based options. We will engage with communities to cultivate buy-in and develop solutions that reflect the needs of all New Zealanders.

AJP believes that instigating plant-based food by default in public institutions is an effective low-regrets step that can be taken now and that will support a shift away from animal-based foods. It will lead to better health and environmental outcomes and reduce demand for products that cause immeasurable animal suffering.

Key Objectives:

1. Introduce plant-based menus at all public institutions and events, with plant-based food the default option (animal-based options available on request).
2. Use public procurement to increase demand for plant-based foods and reduce demand for animal-based foods.
3. Support the Plant Based Treaty.

Ensure fair and transparent labelling

The AJP proposes to mandate fair and transparent food labelling that provides information about the environmental, health and animal welfare impacts of food and drink products.

At the current time very little information is provided to consumers about the impacts of the food and drink products they buy. Even when there is strong scientific evidence - for example that processed red meats cause cancer - this is not communicated on packaging, in contrast to other harmful products like tobacco. Furthermore, many of the marketing terms used on food and drink products are not standardised (such as 'natural' and 'less dairy') - and thus can be misleading to consumers.

By introducing a new mandatory system of labelling we will ensure that consumers have access to the information they need to make more sustainable, healthier and compassionate choices. This will also support producers who achieve higher standards and help to drive a broader transformation of food supply chains.

Looking internationally, there are examples of good-practice approaches to labelling that communicate information to consumers in a simple, transparent and high impact way. For example in the UK a red-amber-green traffic light system is used to show nutritional information such as levels of salts, fats and sugars. Research has found that this type of mandatory labelling can be effective in encouraging healthier consumer choices.[30]

The AJP believes that consumers have the right to information about the health, animal welfare and environmental impacts of the food and drink products they buy, and that standardised, fair and transparent labelling has an important role to play.

Key Objectives:

1. Adopt a nutrition-based traffic-light labelling system for food and drink products.
2. Mandate the use of clear warnings of health risks where robust evidence exists e.g. cancer warnings on processed red meats as per the World Health Organisation rankings.[31]
3. Introduce greenhouse gas emission labelling on all food and drink products.

---

[30] See: Song et al (2021) *Impact of color-coded and warning nutrition labelling schemes: A systematic review and network meta-analysis.* PLoS Med. 2021 Oct; 18(10): e1003765

[31] https://www.theguardian.com/society/2015/oct/26/bacon-ham-sausages-processed-meats-cancer-risk-smoking-says-who

4. Develop standardised definitions and require mandatory labelling for terms such as ‘vegan’, ‘plant-based’ and related.
5. Ban the use of misleading terms such as ‘less dairy’.
6. Mandate the clear identification of country of origin, alongside the application of import or sales restrictions on animal products that do not meet animal welfare standards applied to domestic production (see Legislation and Regulation Reform for Animal Protection).

Introduce plant-based eating initiatives and improve guidelines

The AJP proposes to launch a range of plant-based, healthy eating initiatives that reduce harm to animals by promoting the consumption of healthy plant-based foods and decreasing consumption of animal-based foods. While improving public health is a valuable outcome, our primary focus is on preventing animal suffering through dietary change. These initiatives will be based on the best-available science, and communicate information in ways that promote transparency and inspire change.

New Zealand's food environment poses challenges for promoting healthier, plant-based choices. While the national dietary guidelines (last updated 2020) make some positive recommendations around plant proteins and limiting red meat, they maintain a strong emphasis on dairy products, likely reflecting industry influence. Educational initiatives like ‘Garden to Table’ demonstrate the potential for teaching children about growing and preparing fresh food, but operate in only a fraction of schools due to limited government funding.

Meanwhile, the public faces a constant barrage of meat-heavy fast food marketing, with major chains dominating the advertising landscape through sports sponsorship, outdoor advertising and prime-time TV spots. Children in particular are vulnerable targets for food companies, as they struggle to distinguish marketing from fact. While adults are also susceptible to marketing influence, children represent both current customers through their impact on household purchasing decisions and valuable future customers. Adults ultimately control food budgets, but research shows children significantly influence family food choices, making them strategic marketing targets despite not having direct purchasing power themselves.[32] The constant flow of advertising makes it virtually impossible for young people to avoid unhealthy food marketing, effectively normalising unhealthy consumption patterns.

We propose a three-pronged approach:

First, we will launch public media campaigns to build awareness about the health benefits of plant-based foods and the animal welfare concerns associated with animal products. These campaigns will disseminate recipes and information on how to cook nutritious plant-based meals, highlight ethical issues with animal-based foods, and reflect the diversity of New Zealand society and current health inequalities.

[32] https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/1177083X.2024.2344510#abstract

Second, we will review and update New Zealand's dietary guidelines to align with the latest science, including the negative impacts of many animal-based foods. We will ensure it includes guidelines for wholly plant-based diets and clearly articulates the evidence of the benefits these can bring. In recent years many countries have amended their dietary guidelines to increasingly recognise the benefits of shifting away from traditional meat and dairy heavy diets[33]. For example, Canada's 2019 food guide combined meat into a broader protein category and promoted water over cow's milk, and the USA revised it's dietary guidelines (2025) to list pulses and beans as proteins and not vegetables.[34]

Third, we will support educational programmes which increase knowledge and experience with plant-based nutrition and cuisine. This could include, for example, expanding 'Garden to Table'[35] programmes in schools which teach children about growing, preparing and cooking plant-based foods and partnering with Māori educators to deliver culturally relevant nutrition education about plant-based eating and traditional food systems in schools and marae. By funding facilitators, coordinators and resources, we will encourage young people to develop healthy and sustainable food habits. For older learners we will support training programmes for chefs to develop the know-how to cook delicious, nutritious plant-based meals.[36]

The AJP believes that there is a huge opportunity to positively engage children and citizens across New Zealand's diverse communities to encourage healthy plant-based eating. This will also lead to much more sustainable and compassionate diets.

Key Objectives:

1. Launch public media campaigns about the health benefits of plant-based foods.
2. Update New Zealand's dietary guidelines and review the panel of experts engaged in this activity.
3. Expand 'Garden to Table' programmes in schools and plant-based cooking know-how in post-school training.
4. Engage with medical practitioners to:
    a. update and expand plant-based nutrition and health with curricula
    b. hold conferences to enable continuous education on the role of wholesome and nutrition and health.[37]

---

[33] https://www.greenqueen.com.hk/finland-food-based-dietary-guidelines-red-meat-plant-based-protein/?utm_source=substack&utm_medium=email

[34] https://www.today.com/health/news/2025-us-dietary-guidelines-plant-based-foods-rcna183797

[35] https://gardentotable.org.nz/

[36] https://www.escoffier.edu/blog/world-food-drink/how-plant-based-dishes-are-shaping-restaurant-menus/

[37] https://vegmed.org/

5. Implement comprehensive restrictions on the marketing of unhealthy animal-based food and beverages.

Improve access to nutritious food

The AJP proposes to improve access to nutritious food for all New Zealanders through a package of policy measures. While improving access to healthy food is a valuable outcome, our primary focus is on preventing animal suffering through dietary change. These measures will reduce costs, improve access to plant-based foods, support communities to take a lead role, and tackle inequalities and health disparities.

Food access inequities exist across Aotearoa, disproportionately affecting Māori communities.[38] Lower-income areas often have a higher concentration of fast food outlets and fewer fresh food retailers, while transport barriers and distance to supermarkets create additional challenges, particularly in rural areas.

Many communities rely on local dairies (convenience stores) which typically stock limited fresh food at higher prices. These access issues are compounded by the high cost of healthy food. Fresh fruit and vegetables are notably expensive with significant seasonal price fluctuations. Studies of healthy food baskets consistently show that eating according to nutrition guidelines requires a substantial portion of a low-income household's budget, while processed and energy-dense foods remain cheaper per calorie than fresh, nutritious options.

New Zealanders are currently not eating the recommended servings of fruit and vegetables. In 2023/24, 47.1% adults ate the recommended amount of fruit and only 9.1% ate the recommended amount of vegetables per day. For children aged 2 to 14 years the figures are 70.5% and 8.2% respectively[39].

Food insecurity, “insufficient money or resources for a healthy diet; uncertainty about the ability to obtain food; skipping meals or running out of food occasionally”,[40] can lead to an average educational achievement lag of up to four years for New Zealand teenagers,[41] and poor health outcomes and development difficulties for children, with potentially life-long impacts.[42] In 2023/24 rates of food insecurity were higher in

[38] Public Health Advisory Committee. 2024. Rebalancing our food system. Wellington: Ministry of Health.
[39] https://www.health.govt.nz/publications/annual-update-of-key-results-202324-new-zealand-health-survey
[40] https://www.fao.org/hunger/en
[41] https://www.phcc.org.nz/briefing/food-poverty-nz-teens-creating-achievement-lag-four-years
[42] https://thespinoff.co.nz/kai/31-07-2024/around-the-world-food-insecurity-is-improving-in-new-zealand-its-getting-worse

households where children were Māori, Pacific, disabled, or living in the most deprived neighbourhoods.[43]

Healthy and sustainable food must be the most affordable options for households, and food environments need to be actively re-shaped. We will:

- Remove GST from fruits, vegetables, legumes, nuts and other core plant-based foods. This could save just over $1 billion in health costs[44] while making nutritious options more affordable and accessible.
- Create regional food hubs to aggregate and distribute plant-based foods; work with food banks to increase nutritious options; and adjust food assistance programmes to include higher allowances for purchasing plant-based foods (like in the US Government's Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Programme). These initiatives will be developed in partnership with iwi and hapū to ensure they meet the needs of Māori communities.
- Support māra kai and community gardens recognizing their importance in Māori food sovereignty. We will set aside land and fund community champions to establish and maintain these spaces. This initiative builds community, shares knowledge and provides healthy food while honoring traditional Māori food practices.[45]
- Work with retailers to create demonstrable positive impact on the affordability and accessibility of healthy and sustainable diets. This includes addressing the supermarket duopoly to promote competition, establishing targets for meat-to-plant product ratios similar to Denmark's climate-driven approach and reforming supplier contracts that constrain product offerings in dairies. Implement restrictions on price promotions for unhealthy foods, require annual reporting on 'healthy vs unhealthy' promotion ratios, redesign store layouts to prioritise healthier options 'eye level is buy level'[46] and challenge centralisation requirements that disadvantage smaller local producers.
- Develop a National Food Strategy to set out the short, medium and long-term actions for Aotearoa to grow and consume more plant-based foods - whilst also meeting health, environmental, animal welfare and food security objectives. This strategy will be developed in partnership with Māori, ensuring that Te Tiriti principles are embedded throughout. The UK is developing a National Food Strategy in 2025.[47]

---

[43] https://www.health.govt.nz/publications/annual-update-of-key-results-202324-new-zealand-health-survey
[44] https://thespinoff.co.nz/partner/09-07-2024/five-realistic-policy-ideas-for-a-healthier-nz
[45] Public Health Advisory Committee. 2024. Rebalancing our food system. Wellington: Ministry of Health.
[46] https://epha.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/06/epha_2023_the_illusion_of_choice_report.pdf
[47] https://www.agrifood4netzero.net/resources/digest-national-food-strategy-an-update/

Improving nutrition would also ease pressure on our healthcare system, as fewer people would require hospital care for diet-related illnesses. Partnering with general practitioners and healthcare providers could further support this shift, ensuring more people have access to good dietary advice.

AJP advocates for more ambitious Government action to improve access to nutritious food for all New Zealaners, a stance echoed, in 2024, by the Public Health Advisory Committee recommended priority action "That those involved in our food system take action to ensure all New Zealanders have secure access to enough good food."[48] By making plant-based eating easier and more affordable we can create a healthier, more sustainable New Zealand, reducing health inequalities, environmental footprint and animal suffering.

Key Objectives:

1. Remove GST from core plant-based foods to reduce costs and increase access.
2. Create regional and community-led food hubs and adjust food assistance programmes to promote plant-based foods, developed in partnership with iwi and hapū.
3. Foster Māori-led transformation strategies to integrate indigenous perspectives and equity.[49]
4. Support community gardens and initiatives to promote healthy plant-based kai.
5. Work with retailers to improve access to affordable, nutritious food
6. Develop a National Food Strategy in partnership with Māori to take a long-term view.

[48] Public Health Advisory Committee. 2024. Rebalancing our food system. Wellington: Ministry of Health.
[49] Klerkx, L., Turner, J., & Percy, H. (2023) Navigating the rapids of agrifood systems transformation: reflections on Aotearoa New Zealand's emerging mission oriented agrifood innovation system

Objective 2: Use land and water sustainably and compassionately

Ban the most intensive and harmful forms of animal farming and fishing

The AJP proposes to implement an absolute ban on the worst animal farming and fishing practices.

We believe that all forms of animal farming and fishing should be phased out. There are steps we can take now to eliminate the cruellest and most intensive practices, helping to move towards our longer term objectives.

New Zealand's Animal Welfare Act sets out obligations on people in charge of animals (including farmed animals) to meet an animal's physical, health and behavioural needs, and to alleviate pain or distress. However in practice this does not happen. Minimum standards contained in regulations and Codes of Welfare are inadequate, often out-dated and reviewed according to the whims of Ministers, and frequently these minimum standards are not met. In addition, monitoring and enforcement is stretched - the Ministry for Primary Industries (whose main goals are productivity, export opportunities and food safety[50]) employs around 30 inspectors for more than 160 million farmed animals.[51]

We would undertake an urgent review of existing legislation, regulations and Codes of Welfare and update these to strengthen a wide-range of requirements and minimum standards. This would result in the following activities being banned:

- Intensive winter grazing (including feedlots and permanent indoor housing systems)
- Breeding fast-growing chickens
- Intensive animal farming
- Live exports and long-haul animal transport
- Mutilations
- Bottom and conventional trawling

[50] https://www.mpi.govt.nz/about-mpi/

[51] https://www.nzherald.co.nz/nz/animal-cruelty-ageing-farmers-struggles-linked-to-mistreatment-of-animals/QT4PNR5JINC6HIWEQUFOUEWHSY/

For more detail on steps the AJP would take to raise standards for farmed animals, see our policies on Protecting the Rights of Farmed Animals and Ensuring the Welfare and Protection of Marine Life.

The AJP believes there is no place in our society for intensive animal farming and industrial fishing and that these activities should be banned with urgency. This will be a critical step in the transition to a plant-based economy, and will result in less animal suffering.

Key Objectives:

1. Review and urgently update New Zealand's Animal Welfare legislation, regulations and Codes of Welfare - see AJP Legislation and Regulation Reform for Animal Protection policy overviews.
2. Ban the cruellest and most intensive farming and fishing practices - see AJP Protecting the Rights of Farmed Animals and Ensuring the Welfare and Protection of Marine Life.

Introduce tighter standards and enforcement for agricultural pollution

The AJP seeks to address the environmental harm caused by agricultural practices while supporting farmers to transition to more sustainable and plant-based alternatives. Through a combination of regulatory reform, targeted taxation and funding mechanisms, we will create a path forward that ensures polluters pay for the damage they cause. However, this will be no substitute for action which other AJP policies will drive in order to reduce and eliminate the pollution.

Animal farming is a major polluter in Aotearoa, on land and at sea. It is responsible for a 48.6% of our planet-warming greenhouse gas emissions.[52] It also causes effluent and fertiliser run-off which is polluting our seas and rivers, making many of our waterways unfit for aquatic life as well as for human swimming and drinking. Nutrient enrichment, from fish farm releases, leads to eutrophication, promoting excessive algae growth that depletes oxygen levels and harms marine ecosystems. Additionally, animal farming has resulted in the destruction of much needed habitats for endangered species. This pollution is allowed to occur largely unchecked. Regulations are insufficiently stringent, often ignored and rarely enforced.

The huge costs from this pollution are not borne by the polluter - the animal farming industry - but by nature and society at large. This is in effect a subsidy for one of the dirtiest industries in the country.

One of the most urgent measures needed is to include agriculture into an Emissions Trading Scheme (ETS). We would adopt the Climate Change Commission's advice that the current NZ ETS should focus on fossil fuel emissions. A separate, new cap-and-trade ETS for biogenic emissions (including forestry) should be established, which lowers gross methane emissions to agreed long-term flow.[53] This should be implemented as quickly as possible. We will also set separate gross (total emissions produced) and net (emissions after offsets like forestry are considered) emissions reductions targets and reform the ETS to ensure that gross agricultural emissions are reduced, not simply netted off by forestry plantations.

To address other forms of agricultural pollution such as nitrogen run-off, the AJP proposes an urgent review and strengthening of current standards such as the National

[52] https://www.nzagrc.org.nz/news-and-events/race-on-to-reduce-emissions-from-new-zealand-livestock/
[53] Parliamentary Commissioner for the Environment Going with the grain Changing land uses to fit a changing landscape May 2024

Environmental Standards for Freshwater. We will also introduce a pollution tax on pesticides, fertilisers and other relevant forms of agricultural pollution, escalating over time reducing the environmental and ethical harms associated with animal farming and ensuring a healthier environment for all forms of life. We will fund an expansion of monitoring and enforcement capabilities so that polluters are identified and held to account.

We propose to ringfence revenues from the sale of biogenic ETS credits and pollution taxes for a new Fund for Environmental and Agricultural Transformation (FEAT). A substantial portion of increased fossil ETS auction revenue would also be directed to this fund. FEAT will support activities like farm transitions, regional land restoration, environmental restoration schemes and native reforestation.

The AJP believes that pollution from animal agriculture should not be allowed to continue unchecked. As the most intensive and harmful forms of animal farming and fishing are banned, the associated polluting will abate.

This is a transitional policy, ensuring as Aotearoa moves to a truly ‘clean and green’ land where those currently causing damage pay the full cost and in turn help a shift to more sustainable and compassionate uses of our land and water. Toitū te whenua, toitū te tangata (If the land is well, the people will be well).

Key Objectives:

1. Separate the ETS into two schemes: one for fossil fuels and another for biogenic emissions, removing the unlimited forestry offset option from the fossil fuel ETS.
2. Improve regulatory standards and introduce targeted pollution taxes that reflect the true accounting cost of environmental impacts.
3. Create a Fund for Environmental and Agricultural Transformation from multiple revenue streams to support regional control and decision-making.
4. Ensure that Māori landholders are not disproportionately impacted by policy changes and are supported in exercising kaitiakitanga.

Provide financial incentives for good environmental practices

The AJP will support more sustainable and compassionate uses of land and water through financial incentives and regulatory reform. We will create a new Fund for Environmental and Agricultural Transformation (FEAT) to support farm transitions, reduce pollution and harm, and protect and restore natural habitats.

At the current time there are insufficient regulatory and economic incentives for farmers, fishers and land managers to look after land and water sustainably. Initially funding for the Fund for Environmental and Agricultural Transformation would occur by implementing the "polluter pays" principle. Income would be raised from the biogenic Emissions Trading Scheme and the true cost accounting of environmental impacts via pollution taxes. Examples of activities that will be supported through this fund include:

- Support for farmers to shift towards plant-based farming systems and other sustainable land uses (see our Farm Transition Scheme proposals).
- Tax breaks and grants for plant-based farming, including diversified, veganic farming approaches that use regenerative, permaculture and natural principles to restore soil and ecosystems, enhance food security and provide nutrient-dense foods.
- Payments for farmers who adopt practices that restore ecosystems and natural habitats, promote biodiversity, enhance soil health, reduce nutrient run-off and pesticide use, and build natural flood defences and resilience to climate change.
- Auditing and enforcement to ensure practices are enduring.
- Increased funding for marine reserves and marine habitat protection schemes.

In addition we will review and strengthen regulations to encourage the maintenance and enhancement of natural ecosystems. National Policy Statements (NPS) would continue to set the high-level policy direction, alongside National Environmental Standards, coupled with flexible compliance mechanisms that accommodate different land uses and regional conditions (Regional Policy Statements) without undermining the national goals.

Many other countries around the world have implemented schemes that offer financial incentives for better environmental outcomes in the agricultural sector. Examples include the UK's Environmental Land Management Scheme (based on the principle of "public money for public goods") and the conditionality standards and eco-schemes under the EU Common Agricultural Policy. In the Netherlands, 25 billion Euros has been budgeted to support herd reduction to address water pollution from agricultural

wastes.[54] Whilst these programmes are far from perfect, they offer different models and lessons to help inform the design of schemes in New Zealand. An iterative process of policy implementation and learning is needed.

The AJP believes that a transformation in the way we use our land and water is needed to support more sustainable and compassionate approaches, boost animal habitats, reduce animal suffering - all delivering wider benefits to society.

Key Objectives:

1. Create a Fund for Environmental and Agricultural Transformation to subsidise plant-based and ecosystem-restorative farming.
2. Promote regenerative plant-based farming to rebuild soil health, restore ecosystems and protect biodiversity.
3. Offer tax credits for verified emissions reductions and biodiversity restoration.

54

https://www.theguardian.com/environment/2021/dec/15/netherlands-announces-25bn-plan-to-radically-reduce-livestock-numbers

Objective 3: Support farmers, workers and communities to transition

Introduce a farm transition scheme

The AJP proposes to create a new national scheme that provides direct support to animal farmers who wish to transition to plant farming and other economic activities. This farmer-led, government-supported initiative will build momentum and knowledge on viable approaches for diversifying beyond animal farming, while recognising and honouring the unique considerations of Māori land and agricultural practices.

At the current time there are practical, financial and cultural barriers that prevent animal farmers from diversifying their activities and moving away from animal farming.[55] Whilst there are examples in Aotearoa of farmers making positive changes, they are fighting against the tide. The system as it stands is stacked against them, legacy policies and institutional structures favour incumbent systems,[56] and current adaptation strategies often reinforce unsustainable, high-input systems.[57]

There are also knowledge gaps in terms of the most economically viable, sustainable alternatives to animal farming, both in New Zealand and elsewhere in the world, which need addressing urgently as the global food system changes.

However, this concentration into dairying in particular, is a relatively recent phenomenon. Many regions were previously much more diverse, growing crops as well as animals. Pig farming in this country is facing significant challenges as farmers struggle to comply with new regulations and compete with floods of cheap overseas pork from countries with lower animal welfare standards. Similarly, sheep farmers are confronting problems due to climate change-induced weather patterns, an aging farmer population, and decreasing value of mutton and lamb exports. The reluctance of younger generations to enter these industries—including cattle farming—represents a further challenge. These signs point to a broader decline in animal agriculture, creating both urgency and opportunity for transition. The concentration of rural production into animal agriculture means there is great opportunity for diversification in the future.

---

[55] Salliou, N., (2023) Quitting livestock farming: transformation pathways and factors of change from post-livestock farmers' accounts. *Frontiers in Sustainable Food Systems*, Volume 7 https://doi.org/10.3389/fsufs.2023.1122992

[56] Klerkx, L., Turner, J., & Percy, H. (2023) Navigating the rapids of agrifood systems transformation: reflections on Aotearoa New Zealand's emerging mission oriented agrifood innovation system

[57] Griffin, C., et al (2023). 'As a farmer you've just got to learn to cope': Understanding dairy farmers' perceptions of climate change and adaptation decisions in the lower South Island of Aotearoa-New Zealand. *Journal of Rural Studies*, 98, 147-158.https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jrurstud.2023.02.001

Internationally there are examples of inspiring initiatives that are helping farmers to transition. In the US, the Transfarmation Project provides resources and support to industrial animal farmers who want to shift to raising crops for human consumption. Successful case-studies include the conversion of a chicken farm to growing hemp in Texas, and the conversion of an intensive pig farm to a specialty mushroom operation in Iowa.

Our proposed farm transition scheme would learn from these international examples. It would be available to animal farmers wishing to transition as well as to existing plant farmers who are seeking additional support. It would be supported by our proposed Fund for Environmental and Agricultural Transformation with revenue raised from agricultural emissions pricing and taxing agricultural pollution (see our 'Provide financial incentives for environmental good practice' proposal). Likely activities include:

- Farm assessments and transition plans
- Training, resources and educational materials
- Farmer-to-farmer networks and peer mentoring
- Connecting farmers with buyers and supply chains
- Financial and business planning
- Grants, loans and debt restructuring / cancellation
- Reuse of stranded assets, e.g. old meat works gaining new functions

The scheme will include a farmer-led task force, with dedicated Māori representation, to identify regulatory, technological, financial and market barriers, and work with Government to implement changes that address these barriers and unlock the investment needed for more farms to transition. The scheme will continue to develop building land-use change and bioeconomy opportunities, respect kaitiakitanga principles and cultural values while positioning Aotearoa as a leader in alternative proteins.

The AJP believes there is huge potential for farmers to lead the transition to plant-based agriculture in ways that suit each farm's specific needs and local context. We are committed to using the resources and influence of Government to help make this a reality in collaboration with farmers and the community.

Key Objectives:

1. Establish a Farm Transition Advisory Network - a multidisciplinary new farmer-led national scheme to provide direct support to animal farmers who wish to transition to plant farming or other economic activities and identify potential opportunities and barriers.

2. Support farmers through a wide-range of activities including transition planning, training and education, financial planning, grants and loans, and debt restructuring.
3. Ensure meaningful Māori participation and partnership throughout the development and implementation of the scheme.

Support for rural economies to thrive without animal agriculture

The AJP will provide support to rural communities to develop and sustain strong local economies that do not rely on animal agriculture and that are resilient to a rapidly changing global context. We propose to introduce financial and other types of support to local councils, community groups and businesses to shift towards economic activities that foster prosperity and sustainability, and that deliver a just transition to a plant-based economy.

Given the current reliance of many of New Zealand's rural communities on animal agriculture for their economic well-being, it is essential that the transition to a plant-based economy includes a proactive and locally-led approach to protecting rural economies; this would occur via the proposed Farm Transition Advisory Network. Currently the interconnected web of services creates a self-reinforcing economic ecosystem where feed suppliers, veterinary services, equipment manufacturers, pharmaceutical companies and processing facilities are all dependent on continuing intensive animal production, while also generating environmental and social externalities that are often not fully accounted for in the economics of the system.[58]

There is an opportunity to develop more diversified local economies that are resilient to global changes in climate, trade, technology and consumer demand. Potential economic opportunities include horticulture, plant-based farming for emerging market demand (e.g. hemp,[59] oats[60] and quinoa), plant-based food manufacturing, timber and fibre processing, tourism and energy.

We propose to establish a national rural economies programme, funded through our Fund for Environmental and Agricultural Transformation with revenue raised from agricultural emissions pricing and taxing agricultural pollution (see our 'Provide financial incentives for environmental good practice' proposal). Likely activities funded by this Fund could include:

- Supporting local councils and Iwi to develop rural economic development plans
- Financial support for community-led initiatives and new or established businesses

[58] https://www.issuelab.org/resources/43293/43293.pdf

[59] https://www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/48136-Facilitating-the-growth-in-the-New-Zealand-hemp-industry

[60] MacDonald, B. (2018). Southland eyes oats instead of dairy. https://www.newsroom.co.nz/2018/02/18/89428/southland-eyes-oats-instead-of-dairy

- Investments in local infrastructure

Recent examples from other sectors provide useful lessons for a proactive approach to long-term economic development and a just transition. In Queenstown, an Economic Transformation and Resilience Fund supports diversification away from tourism aiming to increase economic resilience and develop higher-paying jobs.[61] In Taranaki, Transition Action Plans address how the local economy can move away from oil and gas production. These examples showcase efforts to build more resilient and diverse regional economies, reducing dependence on single industries and fostering sustainable growth across multiple sectors.

The AJP believes that strong rural economies are central to a successful plant-based transition. Through a community-led approach to co-develop transition plans, with investment and support, rural areas can diversify away from animal agriculture towards more diversified economic models that are not only more compassionate, but also more resilient and prosperous.

Key Objectives:

1. Create a national programme to support the development of strong, resilient and prosperous rural economies during a transition to a plant-based economy, including targeted educational initiatives to address climate skepticism and build community support for sustainable agricultural practices.
2. Provide funding and support to local Councils, Iwi, community-led initiatives and businesses; alongside investments in local infrastructure.
3. Support crop diversification programs.

61

https://www.mbie.govt.nz/immigration-and-tourism/tourism/tourism-recovery/tourism-communities-support-recovery-and-re-set-plan/queenstown-economic-transformation-and-resilience-fund

Reskill workers within, and supporting, the industrial animal system

The AJP proposes to create reskilling and training programmes for those currently working in the animal farming, processing and food industries.

In New Zealand, DairyNZ estimates that around 55,000 people are employed in the dairy industry, generating around $3.4BN in 2019. The Meat Industry Association estimates that there are over 24,000 jobs in the meat processing sector. These jobs are varied in nature but some - such as jobs in slaughterhouses - are seasonal, precarious, and involve poor working conditions and increased risk of a range of mental health issues.

As we shift away from animal agriculture towards a plant-based economy, some animal-farming related jobs will be lost and other new jobs will be created in established and emerging plant-based food and fibre industries. To ensure a just transition and maintain public support, it will be essential for Government and local Councils to take a proactive approach to ensure workers are reskilled and can access these new jobs. Cultural identities and traditions can create resistance to change,[62] solutions will also need to be mindful of this and provide attractive opportunities.

To do this, we will create comprehensive worker training and reskilling programmes developed in partnership with iwi and hapū, to honor the principle of tino rangatiratanga (self-determination). These programmes will be:

- Publicly funded and implemented flexibly to recognise the specific skills and needs of each participant.
- Available to young people who want to go directly into a career in plant-based industries.
- Designed to incorporate mātauranga Māori (Māori knowledge) and tikanga Māori (Māori customary practices) where appropriate.
- Designed to draw on learning from similar programmes from other economic transitions such as the shift from fossil to renewable energy - including comprehensive workforce mapping and a collaborative approach between government, industry and workers.

[62] Griffin, C., et al (2023). ‘As a farmer you've just got to learn to cope’: Understanding dairy farmers' perceptions of climate change and adaptation decisions in the lower South Island of Aotearoa-New Zealand. *Journal of Rural Studies*, 98, 147-158.https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jrurstud.2023.02.001

The AJP believes that a successful transition to a plant-based economy must be fair to all and that new opportunities for employment and prosperity must be provided to those who lose their jobs in the animal-farming industry. Reskilling is essential to making this happen. This transition must also uphold the principles of Te Tiriti o Waitangi and support Māori aspirations for economic development and Kaitiakitanga (environmental stewardship).

Key Objectives:

1. Create reskilling programmes, developed in partnership with Māori, to support those currently working in the animal farming industry to access jobs and opportunities in plant-based sectors.
2. Support a just transition that leaves no-one behind and honors Te Tiriti o Waitangi principles.

Objective 4: Develop long-term economic alternatives

Identify our biggest land-use and bioeconomy opportunities

The AJP believes that the Government should convene a national process of engagement and economic research to identify New Zealand's best opportunities to diversify the economy away from animal agriculture into new land-uses, products and markets.

At the current time our Government is taking a short-sighted approach to agricultural policy. It is disproportionately influenced by the most regressive vested interests and is now weakening environmental and animal welfare standards. Rather than take a position of leadership to diversify the country's agricultural sector away from animal farming, the Government is doubling down on the status quo - an approach which is not only bad for animals and the environment but also economically risky in a world of changing technology and markets.

New Zealand's approach to land-use urgently needs to change to deal with the challenges of climate change, biodiversity loss and water quality.

To address these issues, the Government should lead a national programme to identify the most promising economic opportunities for New Zealand's bioeconomy and land-use, taking into account future market demand, market size, jobs, GDP and export potential. It should:

- Build on work undertaken by the Ministry of Business, Innovation and Enterprise in 2023 that analysed 30 economic opportunities including land-based crops such as pine nuts, hemp and bananas; water-based crops such as microalgae and seaweed; forest based products such native botanicals and medicinal mushrooms; and bioenergy, bioplastics and biochemicals.
- Investigate indigenous plant-based food as industries, such as kūmara, and other native crops, which offer opportunities for Māori-led economic development while ensuring alignment with tino rangatiratanga.
- Focus on region-specific opportunities suited to local land types, geographies, climates and cultural contexts.
- Identify the key steps the Government can take to support these opportunities - such as removing barriers, changing regulations and introducing incentives etc.

- Involve a broad process of engagement and collaboration with farmers, land managers, economists, academics, and the businesses and innovators that are actively developing plant-based products.
- support local food[63], prioritise 'import-replacing'[64] industries that build regional resilience and self-sufficiency.[65] [66]

We also advocate for the Government to develop a new comprehensive national land-use strategy that considers the recommendations set out by the Parliamentary Commissioner for the Environment in 2024[67]. This strategy should support a shift away from animal farming. It should include an integrated catchment approach to land-use planning, devolved decision-making to regional and local authorities with meaningful iwi partnership, and integrate with broader approaches to financial incentives such as pricing biogenic methane and removing forestry from the Emissions Trading Scheme. The Strategy will recognise the particular challenges faced by iwi with returned Crown forestry land, create specific pathways for Māori landowners to gain economic benefits from environmentally beneficial land uses and support iwi-led initiatives that align with te ao Māori business frameworks and kaitiakitanga principles.

The AJP believes Aotearoa's agricultural sector, and the way we use land, have huge potential to be transformed to better meet the needs of both humans, animals and nature. By embracing existing approaches and new technologies with regional control and determination, we can build viable economic alternatives to replace animal agriculture with a diverse portfolio of other products that go beyond an 'extractive industries' model towards high-value, regionally controlled production centered on local needs.

Key Objectives:

1. Identify the most promising region-specific economic opportunities for New Zealand's bioeconomy and land-use to shift away from animal farming, then implement steps to make this happen.

---

[63] https://www.resilience.org/stories/2024-11-05/the-globalized-industrialized-food-system-is-destroying-the-world-we-urgently-need-to-support-local-food-economies/?mc_cid=e66bf4c222&mc_eid=36d5595f33

[64] https://centerforneweconomics.org/publications/the-grace-of-import-replacement/

[65] https://www.politico.eu/article/food-security-eat-less-meat-says-major-report-common-agricultural-policy-cap-eu-farming/

[66] https://newsroom.co.nz/2024/11/12/the-case-for-feeding-our-5-million-first-before-first-tonne-is-exported/

[67] https://pce.parliament.nz/media/qfxluadl/going-with-the-grain-changing-land-uses-to-fit-a-changing-landscape.pdf

2. Develop a new comprehensive national land-use strategy with devolved decision-making that emphasises regional control of resources and financing and supports a shift away from animal farming.
3. Ensure tangible support for Māori landowners to exercise kaitiakitanga and rangatiratanga while achieving economic benefits.
4. Prioritise the development of local production for local needs, addressing the supermarket duopoly and their centralised approach, strengthening regional economies and reducing dependence on volatile export markets.

Become a leader in alternative proteins

The AJP believes Aotearoa can become a world-leader in alternative proteins. The Government should establish a National Centre for Alternative Proteins and dedicated funding for research, innovation and commercialisation.

New Zealand must position itself proactively to avoid the economic vulnerability that historically characterised its response to structural market changes, like the 1960s wool price shock.[68] Rather than treating the growing shift toward plant-based and cellular agriculture as a temporary disruption, Aotearoa should leverage its existing agricultural expertise, research capabilities and innovation systems to become a pioneer in this emerging sector. Funding for alternative proteins grew by 85% in 2024 in Asia-Pacific[69],

New Zealand has a long heritage of agricultural innovation and a strong foundation in agricultural science and research. However at the current time much of this is being directed towards the ongoing exploitation of animals, for example through the development of vaccines, new genetic breeds and alternative feeds to reduce ruminant methane emissions.

There is an opportunity for New Zealand's science and research community to pivot towards plant-based solutions that are better for the environment, the climate and animals. Breaking free from the institutional inertia and path dependence that has historically favored traditional primary sector activities[70] noting New Zealand's institutional arrangements tend to favour the primary sector.[71]

The Vegan Society's Green Protein Report[72] highlights that New Zealand has significant untapped potential for plant protein production. According to the report, transitioning just 15% of animal farming land to plant protein crops could produce the same amount of protein while reducing land use, greenhouse gas emissions, and water pollution.

---

[68] Easton, B. 2023. Learnings from The New Zealand Economic History of Shocks . Wellington: Productivity Commission.

[69] https://www.greenqueen.com.hk/asia-pacific-agri-food-tech-funding-investment-agfunder-report/?utm_source=green-queen-future-food-weekly.beehiiv.com&utm_medium=newsletter&utm_campaign=china-grants-regulatory-approval-for-animal-free-lactoferrin-future-food-weekly

[70] Easton, B as above

[71] New Zealand Productivity Commission. 2021. New Zealand firms: Reaching for the frontier. Final report. Wellington: New Zealand Productivity Commission.

[72] The Green Protein Report

By making a decisive and well-resourced commitment to alternative protein development - including cellular agriculture, precision fermentation, and plant-based innovations - New Zealand can transform its agricultural comparative advantage into leadership in sustainable protein production.

Cultivated meat and precision fermentation offer a transformative opportunity to create a food system that is kinder to animals, healthier for people, and far less damaging to the environment. By producing meat directly from animal cells, cultivated meat eliminates the need for factory farming, sparing billions of animals from suffering while reducing the risk of zoonotic diseases and antibiotic resistance. Precision fermentation allows us to create dairy and other animal-derived proteins without the environmental toll of industrial animal agriculture, slashing greenhouse gas emissions, water use, and deforestation. These innovations provide the same tastes and textures people love, but with dramatically lower impacts—offering a future where we can nourish the world without harming animals or the planet.

This transition demands more than incremental policy changes; it requires substantial investment in research and development, regulatory frameworks that enable innovation, and coordinated support for alternative protein startups and scale-ups. Unlike previous attempts at economic diversification that delivered "sub-therapeutic" results [73], the alternative protein strategy must be backed by material resources and clear policy frameworks to overcome the established institutional arrangements that favour traditional agriculture.

We propose to establish a new National Centre for Alternative Proteins to focus on these solutions - bringing together the best of New Zealand and international talent across science, academia, the farming industry and the policy and finance communities. This will be funded by redirecting the $400 million for R&D into agricultural climate solutions[74] away from animal-based towards plant-based solutions. It will be complemented by a dedicated Research, Innovation and Commercialisation Fund that supports New Zealand based innovators and scientists, and it will be targeted at solutions that have high economic potential for the country.

The National Centre will have a Māori Alternative Proteins Advisory Board with decision-making authority and a Māori Innovation Fund for iwi-led initiatives. Mātauranga Māori will be embedded in research, and co-investment models will enable iwi organisations to hold equity in ventures. Intellectual property protections and benefit-sharing frameworks will safeguard indigenous knowledge, while targeted

[73] Skilling, D. 2020. Frontier firms: An international small advanced economy perspective. Netherlands: Landfall Strategy Group.
[74] https://www.beehive.govt.nz/release/agriculture-come-out-ets

programs will support Māori entrepreneurs and job creation in high-Māori-population regions.

These initiatives will work across the public and private sectors from early stage R&D through to scale-up and early commercial deployment. The National Centre will develop a roadmap of steps New Zealand should take across major opportunity areas and provide a range of grants and concessional finance support. It will also develop innovation clusters that can overcome the path dependence that has reinforced New Zealand's traditional economic trajectory and identify changes needed to the regulatory framework to remove barriers and create market demand for new products.

There is huge potential for innovations in food technology to provide alternatives to animal products (as we have already seen with the popularity of oat milk), and even to provide ‘real’ animal products without farming animals. Whilst this must be done in an ethical way, and should not distract from the very real imperative to reduce consumption and animal farming now, it could make a real difference in reducing farmed animal numbers and animal suffering.

This alternative protein strategy represents a material commitment to economic diversification that acknowledges the institutional and historical barriers that have previously prevented New Zealand from adapting to structural economic changes before they become crises. With climate change advancing and almost fifty percent of New Zealand's greenhouse gases coming from agricultural emissions, moving away from animal agriculture now will help mitigate the size of the crisis. By ensuring Māori are true partners in this journey, the strategy can support rangatiratanga and economic self-determination while drawing on indigenous knowledge that may offer unique insights and innovations in the alternative proteins space.

Key Objectives:

1. Support New Zealand to become a world-leader in alternative proteins through a new National Centre and dedicated research, innovation and commercialisation funding.
2. Redirect existing agricultural R&D funding from animal-based to plant-based solutions.
3. Develop regulatory frameworks that enable rather than inhibit alternative protein innovation.
4. Create institutional structures capable of overcoming the historical inertia that has favored traditional primary sector activities.
5. Position New Zealand to proactively adapt to structural market changes rather than treating them as temporary disruptions.